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THA 231: Rudiments of Directing - Text, Space and the Six Visual Tools

Directing as preparation, composition and communication

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Directing is not shouting instructions from the back of the hall. This pack covers script analysis for directors, the six visual tools named in the department's course description, blocking and composition, rehearsal technique and the director's production paperwork.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Analyse a script for given circumstances, spine and directorial concept.
- Apply the six visual tools: ground plan, composition, picturisation, movement, rhythm and pantomimic dramatisation.
- Block a scene for clarity and emphasis.
- Run a rehearsal with a clear plan and give usable notes.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Script analysis for directors

You cannot stage what you have not understood.

- Given circumstances: time, place, society, relationships and prior events.
- Spine: the through-line of action that holds the production together.
- Units and beats: divide the scene into playable sections.
- Character objectives and obstacles, scene by scene.
- Theme: the argument the production will make visible.

- Design requirements implied by the text.

The six visual tools

These are the department's named tools; know them by name and use.

- Ground plan: the spatial arrangement of set, entrances and furniture.
- Composition: where bodies sit in the frame of the stage or camera.
- Picturisation: composing stage pictures that tell the story.
- Movement: planned and motivated physical action across the space.
- Rhythm: pace, pause and tempo changes that shape tension.
- Pantomimic dramatisation: telling story through physical action without words.

> **Directing is choosing**
> A production without choices becomes a reading. Decide what the audience should notice in each beat, then use the tools to make them notice it.

Rehearsal and notes

Rehearsal technique is a professional skill in its own right.

- Plan each rehearsal with a goal, a sequence and a stopping point.
- Start with table work before blocking if the text is dense.
- Give notes that are specific, playable and few.
- Never give a note that contradicts the actor's objective without explanation.
- Rehearse transitions, entrances and exits as rigorously as dialogue.
- Keep a prompt script with blocking and cues.

Directing is decided in advance

The common image of a director is someone shouting instructions. In practice, directing is mostly preparation: reading the script until you can say what it is about in one sentence, deciding what the audience must feel at each turn, and then building a plan that produces those effects. Rehearsal is where the plan meets the actors, not where the plan is invented.

Start with the through-line: whose story is it, what do they want, and what does the play do to them? Then choose a spine for the production - an interpretation that gives every scene a purpose. A production without a spine is a collection of well-acted scenes that do not add up.

The six visual tools are the director's compositional vocabulary: level, balance, contrast, focus, rhythm and proportion. They are taught because they are checkable. Before you tell an actor to move, ask which tool the move is serving. If none, the move is decoration.

The six visual tools in use